



EI-SCORE

Explainable-Interpretable
Simple Customized Overall Ranking Engine

User Guide

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1. Introduction

EI-SCORE is an interactive, browser-based application for building Explainable and Interpretable Composite Indicators using decision rules. It uses the Dominance-based Rough Set Approach (DRSA) (Greco et al., 2001) as described in Corrente et al. (2026)

The tool is designed for researchers, analysts, and decision-makers who need to rank or classify a set of units (countries, companies, students, patients, etc.) evaluated on multiple criteria, and who require transparent, human-readable justifications for the classification/scoring assigned.

1.1 Key features

- **Classification problems** - assigning alternatives to ordered classes (e.g., low, medium, high)
- **Scoring problems** - evaluating and ranking alternatives by a continuous score
- **Rule induction** - inducing at-least ($\mathcal{R}^{\geq}$) and at-most ($\mathcal{R}^{\leq}$) decision rules from reference units
- **Full pipeline** - inducing a maximal and a minimal set of rules able to classify or score all units without any contradiction
- **New unit assignment** - select a maximal and minimal set of rules able to classify or score with no contradiction a new set of units together with the previous one
- **Rule reuse** - visualize saved rules and apply to every dataset matching criteria
- **Missing value support** - automatic detection and handling missing data

References

- Salvatore Corrente, Salvatore Greco, Roman Słowiński, and Silvano Zappalà. An explainable and interpretable composite indicator based on decision rules. *Omega*, 142:103513, 2026. doi: 10.1016/j.omega.2026.103513.
- Salvatore Greco, Benedetto Matarazzo, and Roman Słowiński. Rough sets theory for multicriteria decision analysis. *European journal of operational research*, 129(1):1–47, 2001. doi: 10.1016/S0377-2217(00)00167-3.

2. Installation and Launch

EI-SCORE can be used in two ways: as a locally installed application or via a web browser without any installation.

2.1 Option A - Web access (no installation required)

The application is publicly available online. Simply open the following URL in your browser:

```
https://ei-score.streamlit.app
```

No Python or package installation is required.

2.2 Option B - Local installation

Requirements:

- Python 3.14.3 or later
- numpy==2.4.2, pandas==3.0.1, scipy==1.17.0, streamlit==1.58.0 openpyxl==3.1.5

Step 1 - Clone the repository:

```
git clone https://github.com/silvanozap/Explainable-composite-indicator.git
cd Explainable-composite-indicator
```

Step 2 - Install dependencies:

```
pip install -r requirements.txt
```

Step 3 - Launch the application:

```
streamlit run drsa/interface/app.py
```

The application opens automatically at <http://localhost:8501>.

3. Input File Formats

3.1 Units file - load units in EI-SCORE

The data file must be a EXCEL, CSV or TXT file with the following structure:

```
Name,criterion_1,criterion_2,...,criterion_k,assignment
A1,4,3,2,1
A2,5,4,3,2
A3,7,6,5,
A4,6,5,4,
```

- **First column** (optional): unit names. If the first column contains non-numeric values, it is automatically interpreted as unit names.
- **Criteria columns**: numeric values. Any column separators (comma, semicolon, tab, space) are supported and selectable in the interface.
- **Last column**: class/score label with increasing direction.
 - Numeric value → **reference unit** (used for rule induction)

– Empty / NaN → **non-reference unit**

- **Missing values:** empty cells in criteria columns are detected and handled automatically.

It is possible to use a comma (,), semicolon (;), or tab (Tab) as a separator. Files must be encoded as UTF-8. When uploading an Excel file, it must respect the same structure, with the dataset already organized into columns.

Tip

Sample data files covering all use cases are available in the **examples/** folder of the repository, and can also be downloaded directly from the DATA & SETUP tab.

Warning

The class/score label has an increasing direction of preference

The units file can be uploaded in the SIDEBAR, NEW UNITS, APPLY RULES tabs (Sections 4, 7 and 8).

3.2 Rules file (classification) - Load previous classification rules induced

Rules assigning a classification exported from the application or created manually follow this format:

```
#directions,increasing,decreasing,...
#mode,class
type,assignment,criterion_1,criterion_2,...
at-least,2,0.762,,
at-most,1,,2.71,
```

- **#directions:** preference direction of each criterion (increasing or decreasing)
- **#mode:** class for classification problems
- **Data rows:** each row is a rule with **type** (at-least or at-most), **class** (assigned class), and threshold values for each criterion (empty if the criterion is not in the rule condition).

For example, the following row:

```
at-least, 2, 0.2762, ,
```

corresponds to an at-least rule classifying units at-least to class 2 if its performance on criterion_1 is at least 0.762.

The rules file can be uploaded in the APPLY RULES tab (Sections 8).

3.3 Rules file (scoring) - Load previous scoring rules induced

For scoring problems, the **#mode** line changes and class values represent score values:

```
#directions,increasing,decreasing,...
#mode,score
type,class,criterion_1,criterion_2,...
at-least,16.67,0.762,,
at-most,0,,2.71,
```

For example, the following row:

```
at-most,0,,2.71,
```

corresponds to an at-most rule giving to a unit at-most score 0 if its performance on criterion_2 is at most 2.71.

The rules file can be uploaded in the APPLY RULES tab (Sections 8).

Tip

Sample rules files for both classification and scoring can be downloaded directly from APPLY RULES tab of the app.

4. Tab 1 - DATA & SETUP

The DATA & SETUP tab is the starting point of every analysis. It allows the user to load data, configure the problem, and set all analysis parameters.

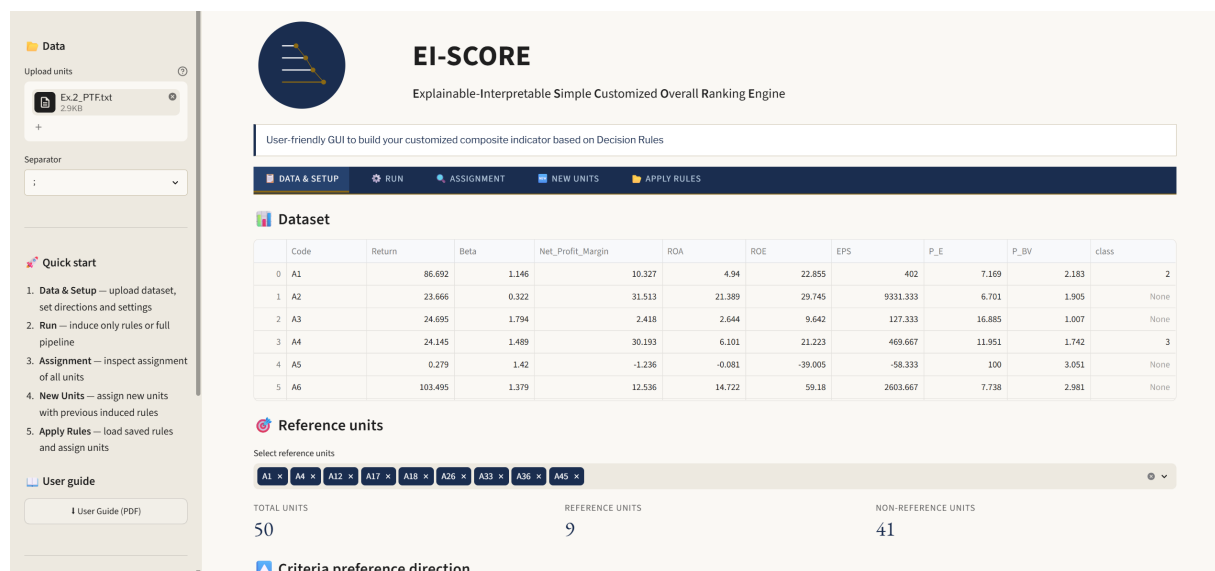


Figure 1: Tab DATA & SETUP - Overview

4.1 Upload data

Click the **Upload EXCEL, CSV or TXT** button in the sidebar to load your data file. Select the appropriate column separator (comma, semicolon, tab, or space) from the dropdown menu. Once uploaded, the dataset is displayed in the main area.

4.2 Reference units

Reference units are the ones whose class/score assignments are known and are used for rule induction. By default, all units with a non-empty class/score label (last column of the loaded dataset) are considered reference units. You can manually select a subset of reference units using the multiselect widget.

Tip

In the Run tab, non-reference units do not participate in *rule induction only* but participate in *full pipeline*.

4.3 Preference directions of criteria

For each criterion, select the preference direction:

- **Increasing ($\uparrow$) (default)** - higher values are preferred
- **Decreasing ($\downarrow$)** - lower values are preferred

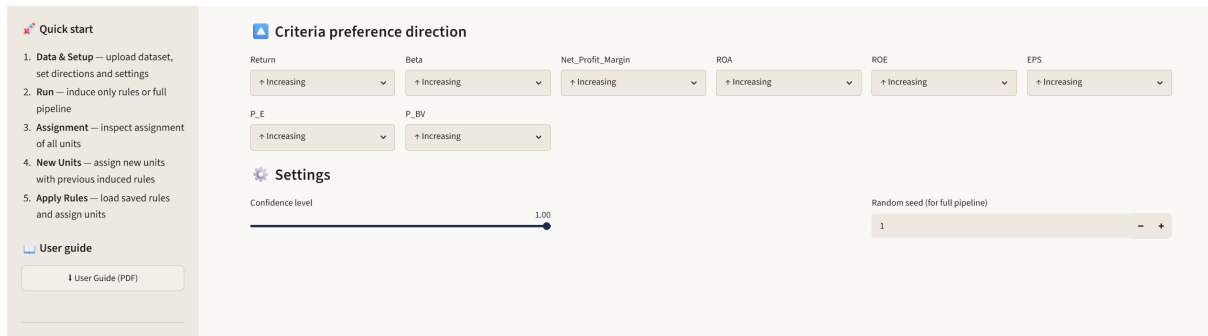


Figure 2: Tab DATA & SETUP - Preference direction of criteria selection

4.4 Settings

- **Min confidence (c) (default: 1)**: minimum confidence threshold for rule induction. Reducing this value allows the induction of approximate rules.
- **Random seed (default: 1)**: controls the random number generator used in the greedy selection step in case of running *full pipeline* in the RUN tab.

Warning

Notice that the loaded class/score must have an increasing direction of preference.

5. Tab 2 - RUN

Tab RUN is where *rule induction* and the *full pipeline* are executed.

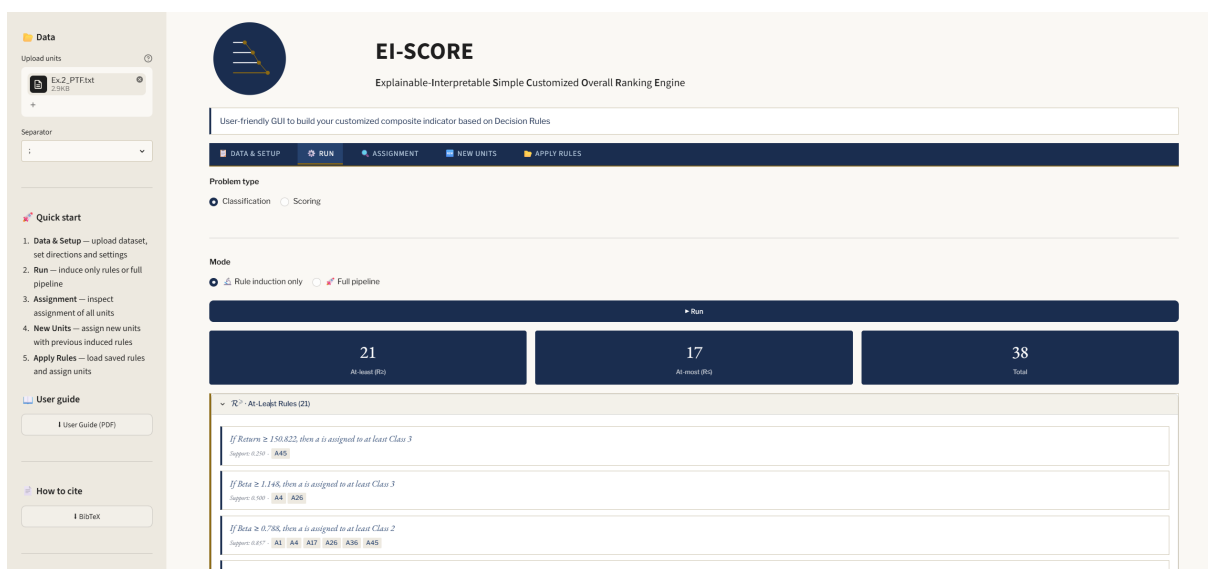


Figure 3: Tab RUN - Rule induction only

5.1 Problem type

Select the problem type using the **Problem type** radio button:

- **Classification (default)** - the last column represents a classification (integer number)
- **Scoring** - the last column represents scores (continuous number).

5.2 Rule induction only

Select **Rule induction only**: induction of at-least ($\mathcal{R}^{\geq}$) and at-most ($\mathcal{R}^{\leq}$) decision rules from the reference units.

The induced rules are displayed in collapsible expander, showing:

- Rule text with condition and decision part
- Support value (fraction of reference units covered)
- Matching units (units matching the condition part of the rule)

Warning

The induced rules may provide contradictory classification for non-reference units in the next ASSIGNMENT tab (Section 6).

5.2.1 Minimal rule set

When all units in the dataset are selected as reference units, the **Find minimal set** button appears below the induced rules. Clicking it solves a Mixed Integer Linear Programming (MILP) problem to find the smallest subset of the induced rules that preserves the same classification of all reference units.

The minimal rule set is displayed below the induced rules, together with a download button.

The screenshot shows the 'Minimal set' tab in the EI-SCORE application. The sidebar on the left contains a 'Data' section with an 'Upload units' button and a file named 'Ex1_HDL.csv' (10.7KB). Below it is a 'Separator' dropdown set to ','. A 'Quick start' section lists five steps: 1. Data & Setup, 2. Run, 3. Assignment, 4. New Units, and 5. Apply Rules. A 'User guide' button is also present. The main content area is titled 'Minimal set' and shows a list of rules under the heading 'Minimal At-Least (17)'. There are four rules displayed, each with a condition, a support value, and a list of matching units. The rules are as follows:

- Rule 1:** If $Expected_years_of_schooling_2022(year) \geq 15.0298$, then a is assigned to at least Class 3. Support: 0.17. Matching units: Switzerland, Norway, Iceland, Hong_Kong_China_SAR, Denmark, Sweden, Germany, Ireland, Singapore, Australia, Netherlands, Belgium, Finland, Liechtenstein, United_Kingdom, New_Zealand, United_Arab_Emirates, Canada, Korea_Republic_of, United_States, Austria, Slovenia, Japan, Israel, Malta, Spain, France, Cyprus, Italy, Estonia, Czechia, Greece, Bahrain, Poland, Latvia, Lithuania, Croatia, Saudi_Arabia, Portugal, Chile, Turkey, Hungary, Argentina, Kuwait, Montenegro, Saint_Kitts_and_Nevis, Uruguay, Antigua_and_Barbuda, Russian_Federation, Georgia, Barbados, Costa_Rica, Thailand, Palau, Grenada, China, Saint_Vincent_and_the_Grenadines, Brazil, Algeria, Tonga, Marshall_Islands.
- Rule 2:** If $Mean_years_of_schooling_2022(year) \geq 11.3105$, then a is assigned to at least Class 3. Support: 0.17. Matching units: Switzerland, Norway, Iceland, Hong_Kong_China_SAR, Denmark, Sweden, Germany, Ireland, Singapore, Australia, Netherlands, Belgium, Finland, Liechtenstein, United_Kingdom, New_Zealand, United_Arab_Emirates, Canada, Korea_Republic_of, Luxembourg, United_States, Austria, Slovenia, Japan, Israel, Malta, France, Cyprus, Estonia, Czechia, Greece, Andorra, Poland, Latvia, Lithuania, Croatia, Saudi_Arabia, Slovakia, Hungary, Montenegro, Romania, Russian_Federation, Bahamas, Oman, Georgia, Trinidad_and_Tobago, Serbia, Kazakhstan, Belarus, Bulgaria, Palau, Armenia, Moldova_Republic_of, Marshall_Islands, Uzbekistan, South_Africa, Samoa, Kyrgyzstan.
- Rule 3:** If $Life_expectancy_at_birth_2022(year) \geq 76.9\%$ and $Expected_years_of_schooling_2022(year) \geq 15.9345$, then a is assigned to at least Class 4. Support: 0.17. Matching units: Switzerland, Norway, Iceland, Hong_Kong_China_SAR, Denmark, Sweden, Germany, Ireland, Singapore, Australia, Netherlands, Belgium, Finland, United_Kingdom, New_Zealand, United_Arab_Emirates, Canada, Korea_Republic_of, United_States, Austria, Slovenia, Spain, France, Cyprus, Italy, Estonia, Czechia, Greece, Bahrain, Poland, Portugal, Chile, Turkey, Uruguay, Barbados, Costa_Rica.
- Rule 4:** If $Life_expectancy_at_birth_2022(year) \geq 78.475$ and $Mean_years_of_schooling_2022(year) \geq 8.8113$, then a is assigned to at least Class 4. Support: 0.17. Matching units: Switzerland, Norway, Iceland, Hong_Kong_China_SAR, Denmark, Sweden, Germany, Ireland, Singapore, Australia, Netherlands, Belgium, Finland, Liechtenstein, United_Kingdom, New_Zealand, United_Arab_Emirates, Canada, Korea_Republic_of, Luxembourg, Austria, Slovenia, Japan, Israel, Malta, Spain, France, Cyprus, Italy, Estonia, Czechia, Greece, Bahrain, Andorra, Croatia, Qatar, Portugal, San_Marino, Chile, Turkey, Antigua_and_Barbuda, Thailand.
- Rule 5:** If $Life_expectancy_at_birth_2022(year) \geq 69.489$ and $Mean_years_of_schooling_2022(year) \geq 12.4334$, then a is assigned to at least Class 4. Support: 0.17. Matching units: Switzerland, Norway, Iceland, Denmark, Sweden, Germany, Australia, Netherlands, Belgium, Finland, United_Kingdom, New_Zealand, United_Arab_Emirates, Canada, Korea_Republic_of, Luxembourg, United_States, Slovenia, Japan, Israel, Cyprus, Estonia, Czechia, Poland, Latvia, Lithuania, Slovakia, Montenegro, Bahamas, Georgia, Kazakhstan.

Figure 4: Tab RUN - Rule induction only find minimal set of rules

5.3 Full pipeline

Select **Full pipeline** to run the rule induction avoiding any contradictory assignment. It computes:

1. **Step 1:** Rule induction from reference units
2. **Step 2:** Greedy selection of rules that avoid contradictory assignment of all units
3. **Step 3:** Assignment of all units using the selected rules
4. **Step 4:** Rule induction from all units to create the maximal set of rules
5. **Step 5:** MILP-based minimization to extract a minimal set of rules

A progress bar shows the pipeline execution. Upon completion, a summary table shows the number of rules at each step, maximal and minimal set of rules.

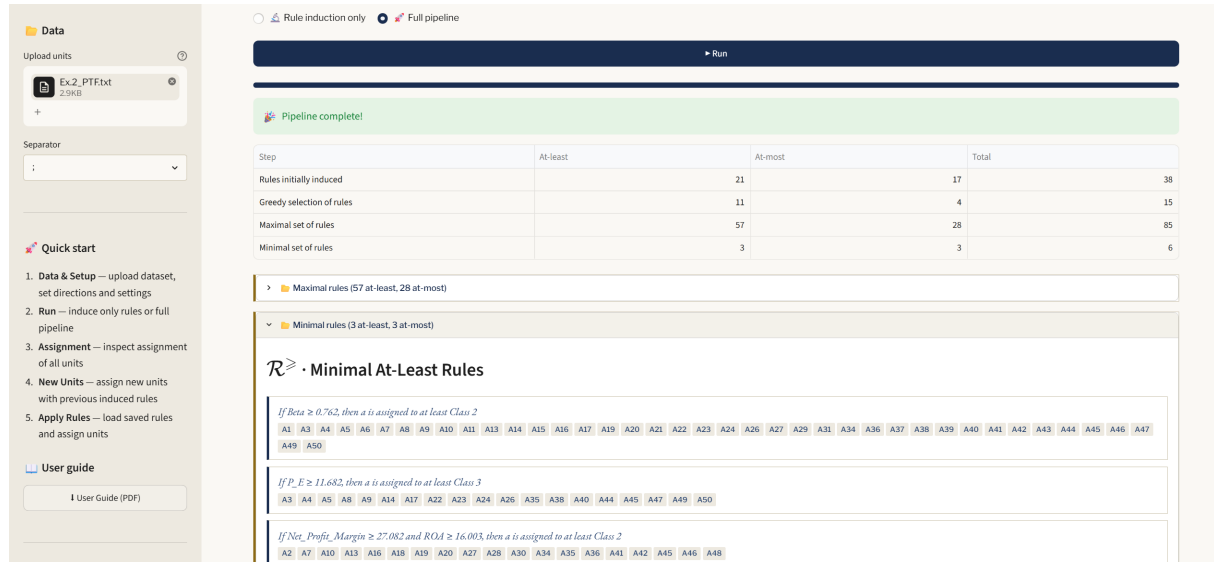


Figure 5: Tab RUN - Full pipeline summary

5.4 Exporting rules

After running, the following CSV files can be downloaded:

- **Maximal rules CSV:** the full set of rules
- **Minimal rules CSV:** a minimal set of rules

Tip

The download CSV can be used to load rules in the APPLY RULES tab.

6. Tab 3 - ASSIGNMENT

The ASSIGNMENT tab displays the decision about of all units using the last induced rules.

6.1 Assignment table

For each unit, the table shows:

- **Minimal assignment:** best class/score supported by at-least rules (lower bound)
- **Maximal assignment:** worst class/score supported by at-most rules (upper bound)
- **Assignment:** classification result

- ☐ Minimal assignment equals to Maximal assignment: unit assigned to a single class/score
- ☐ Minimal assignment is lower than Maximal assignment: unit assigned to a range of classes/scores (uncertain)
- ☐ Minimal assignment is higher than Maximal assignment: contradictory class/score assignment

- **Status:** OK or Contradictory

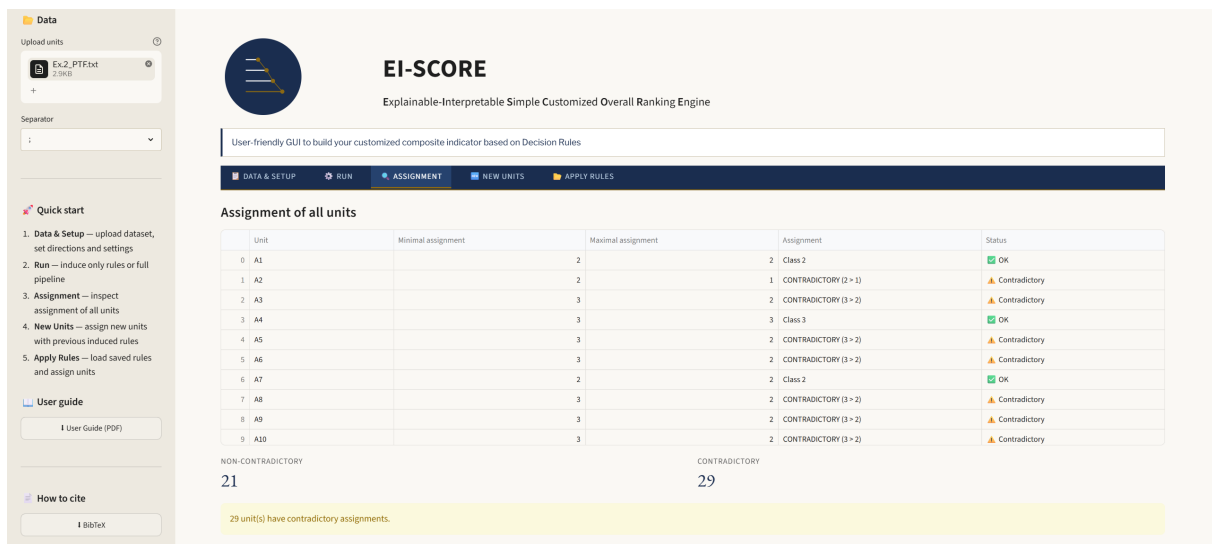


Figure 6: Tab ASSIGNMENT - Assignment table

Tip

Contradictory classification may appear only if you run *Rule induction only* in the RUN tab).

6.2 Unit-by-unit explanation

Select a unit from the dropdown to see a detailed **explanation** of its classification/scoring: which rules were matched, and how Minimal and Maximal assignment were determined.

Unit-by-unit explanation

Select unit

A1

A1 → Class 2

Satisfied at-least rules:

If $Beta \geq 0.788$, then a is assigned to at least Class 2

Satisfied at-most rules:

If $Net_Profit_Margin \leq 10.327$, then a is assigned to at most Class 2

If $ROA \leq 4.94$, then a is assigned to at most Class 2

If $EPS \leq 402.0$, then a is assigned to at most Class 2

If $P_E \leq 9.156$, then a is assigned to at most Class 2

If $Beta \leq 1.146$ and $ROE \leq 22.855$, then a is assigned to at most Class 2

If $Beta \leq 1.146$ and $P_BV \leq 2.183$, then a is assigned to at most Class 2

1 Assignment

Figure 7: Tab ASSIGNMENT - Unit-by-unit explanation

A downloadable CSV file is also available.

7. Tab 4 - NEW UNITS

The NEW UNITS tab allows classifying or scoring new units that were not part of the original dataset.

7.1 Uploading new units

Upload an EXCEL, CSV or TXT file containing the new units. The file must include the same criteria columns as the original dataset. Unit names in the first column are optional. Once uploaded, the table of new units appears.

Data

Upload units

Ex2_PTF.txt

Separator

:

Quick start

1. **Data & Setup** — upload dataset, set directions and settings
2. **Run** — induce only rules or full pipeline
3. **Assignment** — inspect assignment of all units
4. **New Units** — assign new units with previous induced rules
5. **Apply Rules** — load saved rules and assign units

User guide

1 User Guide (PDF)

How to cite

1 BibTex

EI-SCORE

Explainable-Interpretable Simple Customized Overall Ranking Engine

User-friendly GUI to build your customized composite indicator based on Decision Rules

DATA & SETUP RUN ASSIGNMENT **NEW UNITS** APPLY RULES

Assign new units

Upload new units **without** the class column. The tool tries to handle contradictions.

Upload new units

Ex2_PT_units.txt

Separator

:

	name	Return	Beta	Net_Profit_Margin	ROA	ROE	EPS	P_E	P_BV
0	x1	-9.145	0.1	-10.159	-6.553	-47.223	-505.333	2.71	0.773
1	x2	66.644	1.1798	33.0816	17.0123	29.0545	1342.6334	28.2945	2.9225
2	x3	263.307	3.421	144.01	61.141	85.927	9331.333	250	20.786
3	x4	-9.145	0.1	144.01	61.141	85.927	9331.333	28.2945	2.9225

Assign new units

Figure 8: Tab NEW UNITS - New units loaded

Warning

The *full pipeline* must be run in the RUN tab before new units can be assigned to class or score.

7.2 Assignment results

By clicking the button *Assign new units*, a set of maximal and minimum rules is found. Both of them are a subset of the maximal rules found in the RUN tab. The results table shows all original units together with the new units (highlighted in yellow), displaying:

- **Minimal assignment (previous):** initial lower bound classification/score using the maximal set of rules found in the RUN tab
- **Minimal assignment (previous):** initial lower bound classification/score using the maximal set of rules found in the RUN tab
- **Minimal assignment (new):** final lower bound classification/score using the set of maximal rules selected
- **Maximal assignment (new):** final upper bound classification/score using the set of maximal rules selected
- **Assignment:** final assignment
- **Changed:** whether the assignment changed from the initial due to the inclusion of new units and the selection of rules

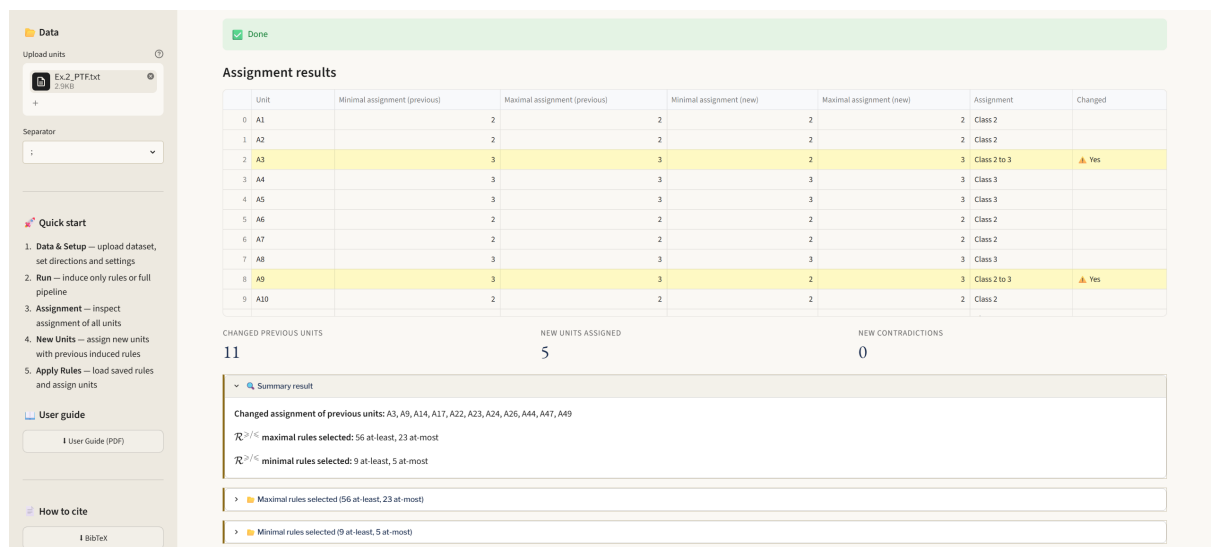


Figure 9: Tab NEW UNITS - New units assignment results

A compact summary result is available showing also the set of maximal selected rules and a set of minimal selected rules able to provide the same classification.

7.3 Unit-by-unit explanation

The unit-by-unit explanation is available for all units (original and new), using the minimal set of rules. Possibility to download units assignment, maximal and minimal set of selected rules.

8. Tab 5 - APPLY RULES

The APPLY RULES tab allows loading a previously saved rules file and applying it to compatible units (with same criteria), without needing to re-run rule induction.

Tip

This tab is always accessible, even without loading a data file in the sidebar.

8.1 Loading rules

Upload a rules CSV file (in the format described in Section 3). The application automatically reads the **#directions** (increasing or decreasing) and **#mode** (class or score) lines to reconstruct the criterion directions and problem type (see Section 3). Upon loading, the application displays:

- Number of at-least and at-most rules
- Criteria names and directions
- List of uploaded at-least and at-most rules

8.2 Visualizing rules

The induced uploaded rules are displayed with the matching units highlighted (if alternatives have been loaded).

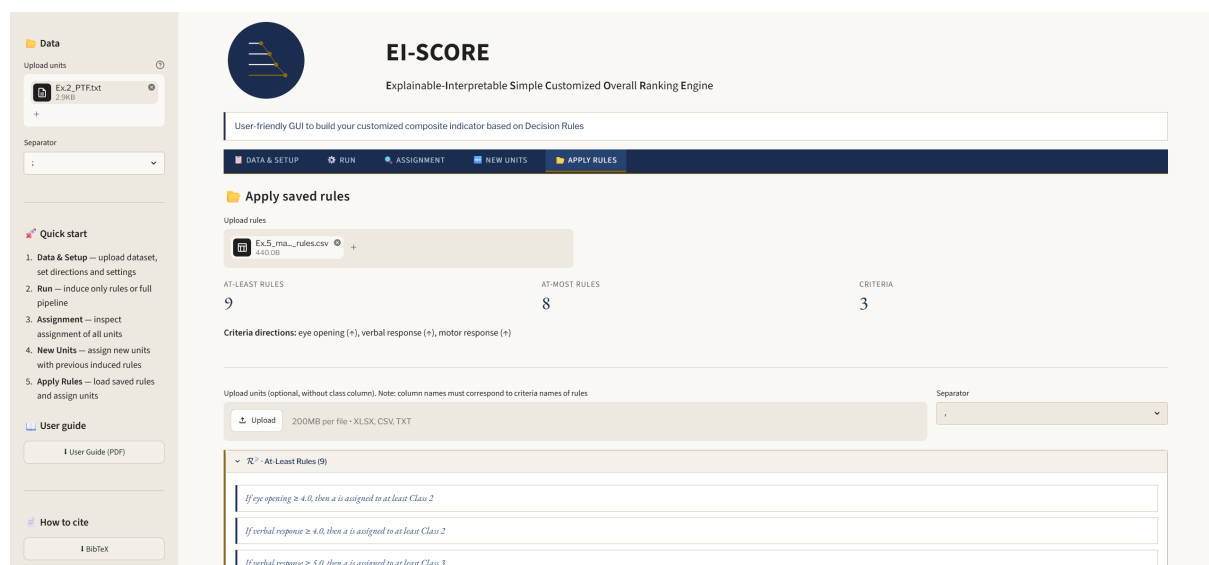


Figure 10: Tab APPLY RULES - Uploaded rules visualization

8.3 Loading units and view assignment

Optionally upload a file of units to assign them class or score using the loaded rules. The assignment table and unit-by-unit explanation are displayed.

Warning

The column names in the alternatives file must exactly match the criterion names in the rules file.

Assignment					
	Unit	Minimal assignment	Maximal assignment	Assignment	Status
0	a1		1	1 Class 1	OK
1	a2		2	2 Class 2	OK
2	a3		2	2 Class 2	OK
3	a4		1	1 Class 1	OK
4	a5		1	1 Class 1	OK
5	a6		2	2 Class 2	OK
6	a7		3	3 Class 3	OK
7	a8		3	3 Class 3	OK
8	a9		2	2 Class 2	OK

NON-CONTRADICTIONY 21 CONTRADICTIONY 0

Unit-by-unit explanation

Select unit

a1

a1 → Class 1

No at-least rule satisfied → Minimal assignment = 1

Satisfied at-most rules:

If eye opening ≤ 2.0, then a is assigned to at most Class 2

If verbal response ≤ 2.0, then a is assigned to at most Class 1

If motor response ≤ 4.0, then a is assigned to at most Class 2

Figure 11: Tab APPLY RULES - Assignment results from uploaded induced rules

8.4 Load a new unit dataset

After loading a set of rules and a set of units with non-contradictory assignments, one may investigate if the introduction of new units affect rules selection and all the units assignments.

Assignment results							
	Unit	Minimal (previous)	Maximal (previous)	Minimal (new)	Maximal (new)	Assignment	Changed
13	a14		3	3	2	3 Class 2 to 3	Yes
14	a15		1	1	1	1 Class 1	
15	a16		1	1	1	1 Class 1	
16	a17		2	2	2	2 Class 2	
17	a18		3	3	3	3 Class 3	
18	a19		2	2	2	2 Class 2	
19	a20		1	1	1	1 Class 1	
20	a21		3	3	3	3 Class 3	
21	a22		2	2	1	1 Class 1	New
22	a23		3	1	1	1 Class 1	New

CHANGED PREVIOUS UNITS 2 NEW UNITS ASSIGNED 2 NEW CONTRADICTIONS 0

Summary result

Changed assignment of previous units: a13,a14

$\mathcal{R}^{>/<}$ maximal rules selected: 8 at-least, 5 at-most

$\mathcal{R}^{>/<}$ minimal rules selected: 3 at-least, 3 at-most

Maximal rules selected (8 at-least, 5 at-most)

Minimal rules selected (3 at-least, 3 at-most)

Unit-by-unit explanation

Select unit

a1

a1 → Class 1

Figure 12: Tab APPLY RULES - Assignment results and rule selection after new units uploaded

The shown information are similar to the one in Section 7.2. Moreover, unit-by-unit explanation, and CSV download are also available.

Tip

The result would be the same of running full pipeline in the RUN tab, consequentially, running the NEW UNITS tab.

9. Examples

All example files are available in the `examples/` folder of the repository ([link](#)).

9.1 Example 1 - Human Development Index

Files: `examples/Ex.1_HDI.csv`

Problems: Inducing rules + inducing minimal set of rules (all reference units) + classification

Dataset: 193 countries evaluated on 4 criteria (life expectancy, expected years of schooling, mean years of schooling, GNI per capita), assigned to 4 development classes.

Directions: all increasing (↑)

Workflow:

1. SIDEBAR: upload `Ex.1_HDI.csv` and set the separator `,`
2. DATA & SETUP: set all criteria as increasing and ensure all units are recognized as reference ones
3. RUN: set *Classification* and *Rule induction only*. Click on Run
4. RUN: inspect induced rules
5. RUN: click on Find minimal set
6. RUN: inspect minimal set of rules
7. ASSIGNMENT: inspect the countries assignment

9.2 Example 2 - Stock Portfolio

Files: `examples/Ex.2_PTF.txt`, `examples/Ex.2_PTF_new_units.txt`

Problem: Full pipeline + New units

Dataset: 50 stocks evaluated on 8 financial criteria (Return, Beta, Net Profit Margin, ROA, ROE, EPS, P/E, P/BV), assigned to 3 performance classes.

Directions: all increasing (↑)

Workflow:

1. SIDEBAR: upload `Ex.2_PTF.txt` and set `;` as separator
2. DATA & SETUP: set all criteria as increasing
3. RUN: select *Full pipeline* and click on Run
4. ASSIGNMENT: inspect stocks assignment
5. NEW UNITS: upload `Ex.2_PTF_new_units.txt` and set `;` as separator. Click on Assign new units
6. NEW UNITS: inspect any changes

9.3 Example 3 - Scored units

Files: examples/Ex.3_ElectreScore.txt

Problem: Scoring

Dataset: 10 investment projects evaluated on 5 criteria, ranked by a continuous score from 0 to 100.

Directions: g1 ↓, g2 ↓, g3 ↑, g4 ↑, g5 ↑ **Workflow:**

1. SIDEBAR: upload Ex.3_ElectreScore.txt and select '\t' as separator
2. DATA & SETUP: set criterion directions;
3. RUN: select *Scoring* as problem type, select *Rule induction only* and click on Run
4. RUN: inspect rules - note that rules decision part shows original score values
5. ASSIGNMENT: inspect assignment (shows score values)

9.4 Example 4 - Missing Values

Files: examples/Ex.4_MISSING.csv, examples/Ex.4_MISSING_new_units.csv

Problem: Full pipeline + Class assignment with missing values

Dataset: 20 students evaluated on 3 criteria (mathematics score, reading score, socioeconomic index), assigned to 3 performance classes. Several missing values are present.

Directions: all increasing (↑) **Workflow:**

1. SIDEBAR: upload Ex.4_MISSING.csv and set ',' as separator
2. DATA & SETUP: inspect NaN/missing values are correctly recognized
3. RUN: select **Classification** and *Full pipeline*. Click on Run
4. ASSIGNMENT: inspect class assignment
5. NEW UNITS: upload Ex.4_MISSING_new_units.csv and select ',' as separator. Click on Assign new units and inspect

9.5 Example 5 - Apply Rules

Files: examples/Ex.5_GCS_original.xlsx, examples/Ex.5_GCS_new_units.xlsx, examples/Ex.5_maximal_rules.csv

Problem: Load previous induced rules + assign units + assign new units

Dataset: Pre-computed rules for the GCS dataset (9 at-least, 8 at-most rules, 3 criteria, class mode).

Workflow:

1. APPLY RULES: upload Ex.5_maximal_rules.csv and inspect the upload rules
2. APPLY RULES: upload Ex.5_GCS_original.xlsx and inspect their class assignment and unit-by-unit explanation
3. APPLY RULES: upload Ex.5_GCS_new_units.xlsx and click on *Assign new units*
4. APPLY RULES: inspect new units assignment

10. Troubleshooting

10.1 File format errors

- **“Could not read file: ...”**: the application could not parse the uploaded file. The most common cause is a mismatch between the actual file separator and the separator selected in the dropdown (comma, semicolon, tab, space). Try changing the separator and re-uploading.
- **“Could not parse the file correctly. The dataset must have at least one criterion and one class column. Check the separator setting.”**: the file was read but resulted in a single column, meaning the separator is wrong. Change the separator dropdown to match the file format.
- **Criteria columns show unexpected values**: ensure that the class/score label is in the last column of the file. All intermediate columns are treated as criteria.
- **Non-numeric values in criteria**: columns with text values are treated as unit names (first column) or ignored. Ensure all criteria columns contain numeric values only.
- **No reference units detected**: if all class/score labels are empty, no rules can be induced. Ensure that at least some units have a numeric entry in the last column.
- **Excel files with multiple sheets**: when uploading an `.xlsx` file, only the first sheet is read. Ensure that the data is in the first sheet.

10.2 Data & Setup errors

- **“Please select at least one reference unit.”**: at least one reference unit must be selected in the multiselect widget before proceeding to Tab Run.
- **“Reference units must cover at least 2 distinct classes to induce rules. Please select reference units from at least 2 different classes.”**: rule induction requires reference units from at least two distinct classes. If all selected reference units belong to the same class, no rules can be induced. Add reference units from a second class, or check that the class column in the dataset is correctly populated.

10.3 Rules file errors (Tab Apply Rules)

- **“Missing #directions line in rules file. The rules file must start with a line like: #directions,increasing,decreasing,...”**: the uploaded rules file does not contain the required metadata header. Check the file format described in Section 3.
- **“Missing #mode line in rules file. The rules file must contain a line like: #mode,class or #mode,score”**: the rules file is missing the mode declaration. Add a `#mode,class` or `#mode,score` line after the `#directions` line.
- **“The rules file contains no rules.”**: the rules file was parsed correctly but contains no rule rows. Check that the file has data rows below the header.
- **“The uploaded units file has no criteria columns matching the rules. Expected: ... Please upload a file with the same criteria names.”**: none of the column names in the units file match the criterion names declared in the rules file. Column names are case-sensitive and must match exactly. Extra columns in the units file are silently ignored.
- **“Missing criteria: ... These will be treated as NaN.”**: some criteria declared in the rules file are absent from the units file. The missing criteria will be treated as missing values. If this is unintended, check the column names.

- **“The uploaded units file is empty.”**: the units file contains no data rows. Upload a non-empty file.
- **“The uploaded units file contains no valid numeric values.”**: all values in the units file are non-numeric or missing after parsing. Check that the file uses the correct separator and that criteria columns contain numeric data.
- **Wrong #mode**: if rules were exported from a scoring problem, the file contains `#mode,score`. Loading it in Tab Apply Rules will display score values instead of class indices. This is correct behavior.

10.4 New units errors (Tab New Units and Tab Apply Rules)

- **“The uploaded file has no criteria columns matching the original dataset. Expected: ... Please upload a file with the same criteria names.”** (Tab New Units): none of the column names in the new units file match the criterion names of the original dataset. Column names must match exactly (case-sensitive). Extra columns are ignored.
- **“Missing criteria columns: ... These will be treated as NaN.”**: some criteria are absent from the new units file and will be treated as missing values.
- **“The uploaded file contains no valid numeric values.”**: the new units file contains no usable numeric data. Check the separator and column contents.
- **“The uploaded file is empty.”**: the new units file has no data rows.
- **“Could not assign new units: ... Make sure the new units file has the same criteria as the original dataset.”**: a dimension mismatch occurred during the assignment computation. This typically happens when the new units file has a different number of criteria than the original dataset.
- **“Unexpected error: ...”**: an unhandled error occurred. Try reloading the page and repeating the operation. If the problem persists, check the input files for anomalies.

10.5 Pipeline errors

- **“Run the Full pipeline first”** (Tab New Units): the New Units tab requires the full pipeline to have been completed in Tab Run. Go to Tab Run, select *Full pipeline*, and click **Run**.
- **“No rules could be induced. Check that reference units cover at least 2 classes and the confidence level is not too high.”**: rule induction returned an empty rule set. This can happen if the confidence level slider is set too high, or if the reference units do not provide sufficient information to distinguish between classes. Try lowering the confidence level or reviewing the reference unit selection.
- **“MILP minimisation failed (...). Using maximal rules (... at-least, ... at-most) instead.”**: the MILP solver could not find a minimal set of rules within the time or feasibility constraints. The application automatically falls back to the maximal rule set. Results remain valid; only the minimality guarantee is lost.
- **Rule induction takes a long time**: for large datasets or datasets with many contradictions, rule induction and the MILP step may take several minutes. This is expected behavior.

How to Cite

If you use this software in your research, projects, or publications, please cite the following papers.

- Corrente, S., Greco, S., Słowiński, R., & Zappalà, S. (2026). *An explainable and interpretable composite indicator based on decision rules*. Omega, 142, 103513. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.omega.2026.103513>
- Greco, S., Matarazzo, B., & Słowiński, R. (2001). *Rough sets theory for multicriteria decision analysis*. European Journal of Operational Research, 129(1), 1-47. [https://doi.org/10.1016/S0377-2217\(00\)00167-3](https://doi.org/10.1016/S0377-2217(00)00167-3)

For BibTeX users you can cite them directly in your L^AT_EX document using `\cite{corrente2026}` and `\cite{greco2001}`:

```
@article {corrente2026,
title = { An explainable and interpretable composite indicator
based on decision rules },
author = { Corrente, Salvatore and Greco, Salvatore and S{\l}owi\{'n}
ski, Roman and Zappal\{'a}, Silvano },
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title = { Rough sets theory for multicriteria decision analysis
},
author = {Greco, Salvatore and Matarazzo, Benedetto and
S{\l}owi\{'n}ski, Roman},
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volume = {129},
number = {1},
pages = {1 - 47},
year = {2001},
publisher = { Elsevier },
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